



Out of sight but not out of mind: The role of loneliness and hope in remote work and in job engagement

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ABSTRACT

In a world in which remote and hybrid work is becoming the new normal, the current study examines the relationship between remote work and job engagement and the roles that loneliness and hope play in this setting. Participants were 349 employees from the US and UK (170 men, 177 women, and two others), aged 21–69 ($M = 38.8$, $SD = 9.9$). The analysis identified a moderated mediation model. Among employees with low levels of loneliness, no significant relationship between remote work and job engagement was found. Remote work predicted decreased job engagement only for employees with high and moderate levels of loneliness. These results challenge the widespread assumption that remote work impairs employee engagement. Yet among employees with high levels of loneliness, hope served as a mediator between remote work and job engagement. Increasing hope may serve as an applicable intervention among lonely remote workers. Implications of our findings are discussed and interventions to increase engagement among remote and lonely employees are suggested.

1. Introduction

Remote work – also referred to as technology-mediated work or telework – relates to work from home or other out-of-office locations. It is fundamentally different from traditional work in terms of proximity to coworkers and supervisors as well as the organizational ability to supervise and control work (Barsness et al., 2005). In addition, nowadays organizations allow “hybrid work” from both home and the physical workplace, such that the employees interact with others in relation to their work activities both virtually and face-to-face (Halford, 2005). In the present study, we follow Barsness et al.'s (2005) operationalization of the remote work concept as “the proportion of time a respondent spent working in a different location than his or her supervisor” (p. 407).

Remote work has increased dramatically in the past years, diminishing employees' organizational visibility and reducing workplace social interactions (Barsness et al., 2005). The literature has emphasized both its merits and potential detrimental effects on employee well-being (Perry et al., 2018). A major external catalyst for this change has been the COVID-19 pandemic (Dubey & Tripathi, 2020). Before COVID-19, approximately 15 % of employees in the US worked remotely at least part of the time. At certain times during COVID-19 lockdowns,

approximately 50 % worked from home (Sull et al., 2020). With this dramatic transition to remote work, questions began to arise regarding the maintenance of employees' engagement with organizations and emotional attachment to them.

1.1. Remote work and job engagement

There are many definitions for “job engagement,” but most emphasize it as a multidimensional concept (Rich et al., 2010; Schaufeli & Bakker, 2004). Specifically, Rich et al. (2010) suggested a holistic conceptualizations of job engagement as representing “simultaneous investment of cognitive, affective, and physical energies into role performance” (p. 617).

One of the concerns that arose with the shift to remote work was that employee engagement would be affected. Molino et al. (2020) discussed the stress that may be related to the increased use of technological tools and its possible impact on job engagement. Others (Kirchner et al., 2021; Perry et al., 2018) addressed the lack of control and supervision in remote work. Finally, recent findings showed that remote work was characterized by a significant decline in internal organizational communication (Yang et al., 2022), which could eventually lead to

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decreased emotional investment in the organization.

Given these findings, we ask whether in the future, when a significant part of the workforce is accustomed to working remotely, job engagement will necessarily be affected. What are the conditions that may hinder engagement? What forces will make it possible to overcome possible damage to engagement?

1.2. Loneliness and remote work

Remote work necessarily entails physical and social distance from the workplace, hence the relevance of loneliness. While social isolation is an objective lack of interactions with others, loneliness is related to the subjective sense of lack of social connections (Leigh-Hunt et al., 2017). It is an unpleasant and subjective evaluation related to the lack of an intimate relationship or wider social interactions, that might be highlighted in objective cases of social isolation (Gierveld & Tilburg, 2006).

In the current study, remote work is considered to be an objective circumstance which lead to decrease in social interactions at work. The positive mental health at work was found to be impacted by a decline in social relationships with coworkers (Bulińska-Stangrecka & Bagińska, 2021). Social isolation was found related to increased stress, reduced productivity, and reduced satisfaction with remote work (Toscano & Zappalà, 2020).

Therefore, when social isolation at work increases as part of the implementation of remote work, it is important to examine the psychological consequences that may follow. As loneliness is subjective, there may be significant individual differences between employees. Remote work may not necessarily affect all employees in the same way. For example, those with higher levels of extroversion missed their work colleagues more during the lockdown than those with lower levels (Langvik et al., 2021). Future time orientation was found to mediate the relationship between proactive coping during remote work and perceived productivity (Chang et al., 2021). A recent study found workplace loneliness to be related to decreased employees' engagement with their work (Jung et al., 2021). Hence, we aimed to examine the role of loneliness in job engagement when working remotely.

1.3. Hope as a resilience resource

Hope is one possible personal resilience resource when working remotely. According to Snyder's theory of hope, "Hope is a positive motivational state that is based on an interactively derived sense of successful (a) agency (goal-directed energy), and (b) pathways (planning to meet goals)" (Snyder, 2002, p. 250). Snyder's theory defines hope not as a vague concept that depends on luck, but rather as an internal motivational resource in which one can effectively define goals and identify appropriate ways to overcome obstacles to attain them.

Various studies have identified hope as a mediating mechanism that leads to a sense of engagement. Positive emotions affect hope, which, in turn, affects engagement (Malinowski & Lim, 2015). In the context of remote work, the ability to motivate oneself to achieve a defined goal is very important, and therefore hope may become a highly required personal resource. Specifically, we postulate that to maintain high levels of job engagement, employees' belief in their ability to meet goals (agency) and find ways to do so (pathways) is important for them as they encounter challenging work conditions associated with remote work. Accordingly, employees who work more hours remotely are predicted to report higher levels of the two components of hope.

Research indicates a negative association between hope and loneliness in general as well as during the social distancing period of the COVID-19 outbreak in various countries (Bareket-Bojmel et al., 2021; Laslo-Roth et al., 2021). Therefore, we expected employees who experienced high levels of loneliness to report lower levels of hope.

1.4. The current study

This study focused on remote work and job engagement. Remote work may have complex psychological implications for employees involving both motivators and inhibitors. Our study was based on a moderated mediation model. We hypothesized that loneliness would moderate the relationship between remote work and job engagement, such that employees working remotely who experience high levels of loneliness would also experience decreased job engagement. We also suggested that remote work may not be detrimental to job engagement by default, but only among those who are vulnerable to it in the first place, i.e., workers with high levels of loneliness. Next, we hypothesized that hope—defined as the ability to set goals effectively and find ways to achieve them—would serve as a mediator, thus explaining how remote work can be positively related to job engagement. Finally, we hypothesized that the positive relationship between remote work and hope would apply in particular to workers who experienced low levels of loneliness. See Fig. 1 for the proposed model.

Accordingly, our hypotheses were as follows:

H1. Loneliness would moderate the relationship between remote work and job engagement: employees who feel lonely would experience decreased job engagement when working remotely.

H2. Hope would mediate the relationship between remote work and job engagement: remote work would be positively related to hope, which in turn would be positively related to job engagement.

H3. Loneliness would moderate the relationship between remote work and hope: positive associations between remote work and hope would be found among employees who experience low levels of loneliness.

2. Material and methods

2.1. Participants and procedure

Four-hundred employees from the US and UK were recruited via the Prolific online research platform in exchange for a monetary reward. To ensure the quality of the final dataset, attention check questions were added to the survey. Fifty-one participants who did not meet the pre-screening criteria or failed to answer the attention check questions were pulled from the analysis. We also restricted the study sample (Prolific participants) to "high reputation" participants ($\geq 95\%$ approval rate in previous studies). Three-hundred and forty-nine employees participated in the study, 177 women (51 %), 170 men (49 %), and two self-identified as "other," were employed in an organization for at least 20 h per week (not freelancers). Most (213) participants were from the UK (61 %), and 115 were from the US (33 %). The rest (6 %) marked "other." Participants' ages ranged from 21 to 69 ($M = 38.81$, $SD = 9.95$). The study met ethical requirements and was approved by the college research authority.

2.2. Measures

2.2.1. Remote work

Remote work was measured by the question "How many days a week do you work remotely (from home or elsewhere)?"

2.2.2. Hope

The Hope Scale (Snyder, 2002) assesses belief in one's own ability to pursue desired goals and employ strategies required to achieve them with items such as "I can think of many ways to get the things in life that are important to me." or "I energetically pursue my goals." We used the trait version of the scale for adults, to which the participants responded using an 8-point Likert scale ranging from 1 (*definitely false*) to 8 (*definitely true*), with a higher score reflecting a higher level of hope. In the current study, a Cronbach's alpha of 0.89 was obtained for this measure.

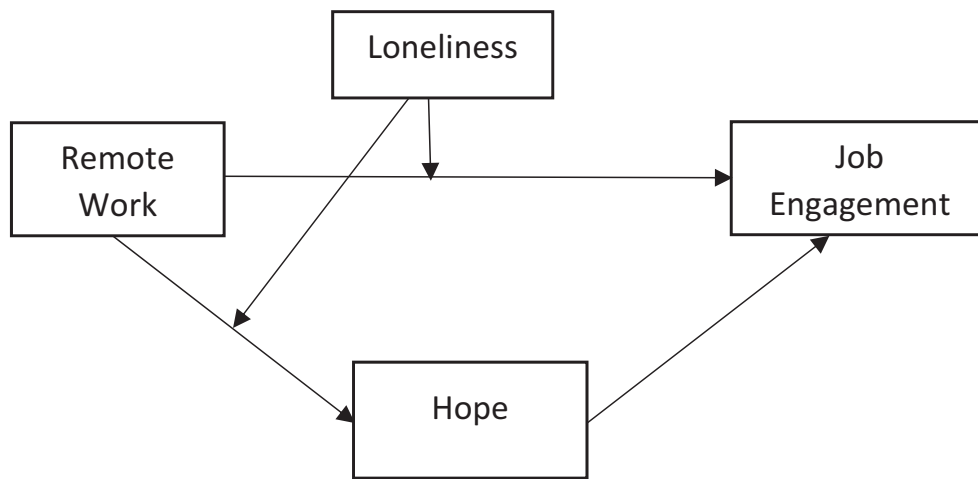


Fig. 1. The proposed model.

2.2.3. Loneliness

Loneliness was assessed by a short questionnaire from the Loneliness Scale of the UCLA Questionnaire (Gierveld & Tilburg, 2006), which includes three items (e.g., “How often do you feel left out?”), and the following general question: “How often do you feel lonely?” on a 5-point scale from 1 (*rarely*) to 5 (*very often*). A Cronbach's alpha of 0.94 was obtained for this measure.

2.2.4. Job engagement

The 18-item Job Engagement Scale (JES; Rich et al., 2010) was used to assess three aspects of the variable: physical, emotional, and cognitive (six items each), on a 5-point scale from 1 (*strongly disagree*) to 5 (*strongly agree*). Sample items from each subscale included: “I work with intensity on my job,” “I am enthusiastic about my job,” and “At work, my mind is focused on my job,” respectively. A Cronbach's alpha of 0.96 was obtained for this measure.

3. Results

3.1. Preliminary analyses

Most (69 %) of the participants reported working remotely at least once a week: 7 % reported working remotely once a week, 12 % two days a week, 8 % three days a week, 7 % four days a week, and 35 % five days a week. One-third (31 %) of the employees reported not working remotely at all, but rather working full time at the organization's offices or facilities.

Descriptive statistics (means, standard deviations, and zero-order correlations) for all variables are presented in Table 1. We also conducted a preliminary analysis of a two-stage hierarchical multiple regression with job engagement as the dependent variable. In the first stage, age, gender, and nationality were entered. Remote work, hope,

and loneliness were entered in the second stage. The regression statistics are reported in Table 2. The hierarchical multiple regression revealed that, in the first stage, age, gender, and nationality did not contribute significantly to the regression model [$F(3, 343) = 1.86, p = .14$]. Adding remote work, hope, and loneliness to the regression resulted significant results, [$F(6, 340) = 28.47, p < .001$].

3.2. Testing for a moderated mediation effect

To test the mediating effect of hope on the relationship between remote work and job engagement as well as the moderating effect of loneliness on this relationship, all while controlling for the age, gender, and nationality of the respondents, a moderated mediation analysis was conducted (Process Model 8, Hayes, 2018). Specifically, to account for non-normal variable distributions, 10,000 bootstrap samples were calculated with a 95 % confidence interval. We centered the values for the construction of remote work, hope and loneliness. Table 3 presents the full model results including standardized and non-standardized ones.

A significant interaction was found between loneliness and remote work in predicting job engagement ($b = -0.04, SE = 0.01, \beta = -0.11, p = .01, 95\% \text{ CI} [-0.06, -0.01]$). Simple slope analysis of the interaction term indicated that for those with high levels of loneliness, remote work significantly and negatively predicted job engagement ($b = -0.08, SE = 0.02, \beta = -0.23, p < .001, 95\% \text{ CI} [-0.12, -0.04]$). Similarly, for those with moderate levels of loneliness, remote work significantly and negatively predicted job engagement ($b = -0.04, SE = 0.02, \beta = -0.12, p = .01, 95\% \text{ CI} [-0.07, -0.01]$). However, for those with low loneliness levels, remote work did not significantly predict job engagement ($b = -0.001, SE = 0.02, \beta = -0.003, p = .96, 95\% \text{ CI} [-0.04, 0.04]$). H1 was thus supported (Table 4).

As for H2 and H3, an examination of the analysis indicated that the

Table 1

Descriptive statistics and correlation matrix for research variables.

	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	1	2	3	4	5	6
1. Job engagement	3.82	0.75						
2. Remote work (days)	2.59	2.14	−0.07					
3. Hope	5.77	1.04	0.55**	0.05				
4. Loneliness	2.29	1.12	−0.27**	0.03	−0.46**			
5. Age	38.82	9.95	0.06	0.02	−0.05	−0.12*		
6. Nationality (UK)	0.61	0.49	0.05	0.16**	−0.05	0.06	0.01	
7. Gender (female)	0.51	0.50	0.10	−0.05	0.03	0.06	−0.04	0.11*

Note: Male gender was coded as “0” and female gender as “1.” UK nationality was coded as “1,” US or other nationality as “0.”

* $p < .05$.

** $p < .001$.

Table 2
Summary of hierarchical regression analysis for variables predicting job engagement.

Variable	Model Step 1				Model Step 2			
	<i>b</i>	<i>se</i>	Beta	<i>p</i>	<i>b</i>	<i>se</i>	Beta	<i>p</i>
Age	0.00	0.00	0.07	.22	0.01	0.00	0.09	.04
Gender (female)	0.05	0.08	0.03	.55	0.12	0.07	0.08	.08
Nationality (UK)	0.15	0.08	0.10	.06	0.11	0.07	0.08	.09
Remote work (days)					−0.04	0.02	−0.11	.01
Hope					0.40	0.04	0.56	<.001
Loneliness					−0.01	0.03	−0.01	.85
Constant	3.51	0.17		<.001	1.22	0.31		<.001
Goodness of fit indices								
R^2	0.02				0.33			<.001
ΔR^2					0.32			<.001

Male gender was coded as “0” and female gender as “1.” UK nationality was coded as “1,” US or other nationality as “0.”

Table 3
The moderated mediation model.

	Outcome: Hope					Outcome: Job engagement				
	<i>b</i>	<i>se</i>	Beta	<i>p</i>	95 % bootstrap	<i>b</i>	<i>se</i>	Beta	<i>p</i>	95 % bootstrap
Age	−0.01	0.01	−0.11	.02	[−0.02, −0.003]	0.01	0.003	0.10	.02	[0.001, 0.01]
Gender (female)	0.11	0.10	0.05	.27	[−0.09, 0.31]	0.12	0.07	0.08	.07	[−0.01, 0.25]
Nationality (UK)	−0.07	0.10	−0.03	.48	[−0.28, 0.14]	0.12	0.07	0.08	.08	[−0.01, 0.26]
Remote work (days)	0.03	0.02	0.07	.14	[−0.01, 0.08]	−0.04	0.02	−0.12	.01	[−0.07, −0.01]
Loneliness	−0.44	0.04	−0.48	<.001	[−0.54, −0.34]	−0.001	0.03	−0.002	.99	[−0.07, 0.07]
Remote work × loneliness	0.05	0.02	0.12	.02	[0.01, 0.09]	−0.04	0.01	−0.11	.01	[−0.06, −0.01]
Hope						0.41	0.04	0.57	<.001	[0.34, 0.49]
Constant	6.21	0.21		<.001	[5.80, 6.62]	1.01	0.27		<.001	[0.43, 1.58]
R^2	0.24					0.35				
ANOVA	$F(6, 340) = 18.32, p < .001$					$F(7, 339) = 25.73, p < .001$				

Table 4
Conditional direct and indirect effects.

	Level of moderator	β	Boot SE	95 % boot CI
Conditional direct effect	$M - 1SD$	−0.003	0.02	[−0.04, 0.04]
	M	−0.12	0.04	[−0.07, −0.01]
	$M + 1SD$	−0.23	0.02	[−0.12, −0.04]
Conditional indirect effect	$M - 1SD$	−0.03	0.04	[−0.04, 0.02]
	M	0.04	0.03	[−0.01, 0.03]
	$M + 1SD$	0.11	0.04	[0.01, 0.07]

interaction between loneliness and remote work was a significant predictor of hope ($b = 0.05$, $SE = 0.02$, $\beta = 0.12$, $p = .02$, 95 % CI [0.01, 0.09]). Simple slope analysis of the interaction term indicated that only for those with high levels of loneliness did remote work significantly predict hope ($b = 0.09$, $SE = 0.03$, $\beta = 0.19$, $p = .006$, 95 % CI [0.03, 0.15]). However, for those with average or low loneliness levels, remote work did not significantly predict hope ($b = 0.03$, $SE = 0.02$, $\beta = 0.07$, $p = .14$, 95 % CI [−0.01, 0.08]) and ($b = −0.02$, $SE = 0.03$, $\beta = −0.05$, $p = .50$, 95 % CI [−0.09, 0.04]), respectively. Furthermore, hope was found to be a significant predictor of job engagement when remote work was controlled for ($b = 0.41$, $SE = 0.04$, $\beta = 0.57$, $p < .001$, 95 % CI [0.34, 0.49]).

We tested for the mediation effect of hope on the relationship between remote work and job engagement at the different levels of loneliness by calculating the bootstrapping confidence interval for the indirect effect of the mediation analysis. The results indicated a significant mediation effect when loneliness levels were high ($b = −0.01$, $SE = 0.04$, 95 % CI [0.008, 0.07]). However, no mediation effect was found when loneliness levels were average ($b = 0.01$, $SE = 0.01$, 95 % CI [−0.005, 0.03]) or low ($b = 0.04$, $SE = 0.01$, 95 % CI [−0.04, 0.02]). Lastly, the mediation effects were found to differ significantly at the different levels of the moderator (loneliness) (moderated mediation

index = 0.02, $SE = 0.01$, 95 % CI [0.002, 0.04]). Fig. 2 presents the obtained moderated mediation model with the effect and significance of each path, and Fig. 3 presents the simple slopes of remote work for hope at the different levels of loneliness. Fig. 4 presents the simple slopes of remote work for job engagement at the different levels of loneliness.

4. Discussion

The introduction of new technologies into the world of work is often accompanied by fears of the psychological effects (Toshav-Eichner & Bareket-Bojmel, 2021), and specifically, in the case of remote work, the fear of distance and detachment from the organization (Adisa et al., 2021; Molino et al., 2020). Yet the advancement of technology cannot be delayed and it seems clear that remote and hybrid work will largely characterize the work structure in numerous organizations in the near future (Alexander et al., 2021). Accordingly, recent studies challenging the widespread assumption that remote work impairs employee well-being ask how the use of technology can be leveraged to promote it (Oberländer and Bipp, 2022; Toshav-Eichner & Bareket-Bojmel, 2021).

In the current study we found that remote work did not decrease job engagement by default. For those with low levels of loneliness, remote work was not related to decreased job engagement. This finding is consistent with a different line of research on employees' attitudes toward remote work. After experiencing remote work during the COVID-19 shutdowns, most employees reported expecting to work remotely at least part of the time in the future (Alexander et al., 2021).

Our findings also demonstrate that employees with moderate and high levels of loneliness are at risk for decreased job engagement. We found that as remote work intensified for employees with moderate and high levels of loneliness, their job engagement decreased.

The study has important implications, sensitizing leaders and managers in organizations to the attachment and involvement possibilities even while working remotely. Technology should be considered as an “enabler”, allowing new possibilities at work (Toshav-Eichner & Bareket-Bojmel, 2021). Many organizations today are dealing with the

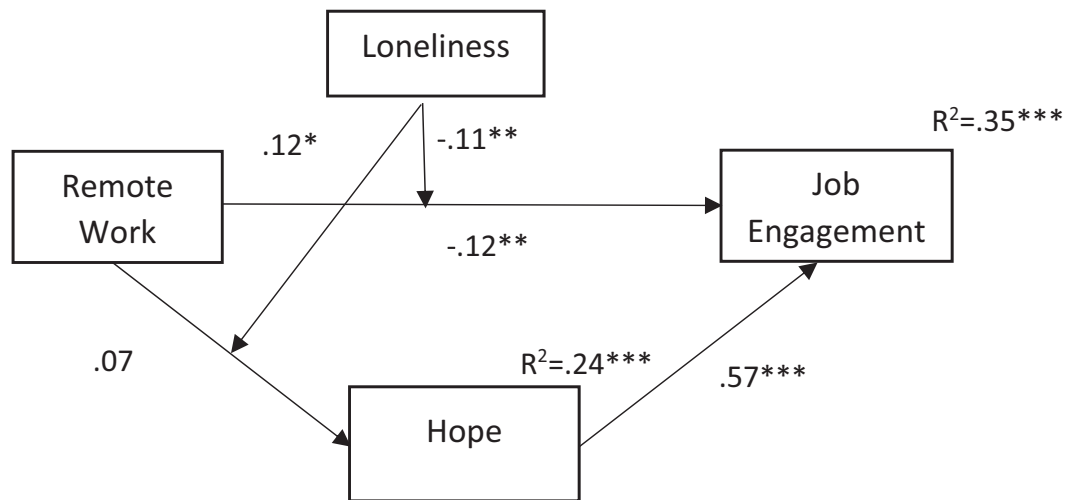


Fig. 2. Moderated mediation between remote work, loneliness and hope, and job engagement.

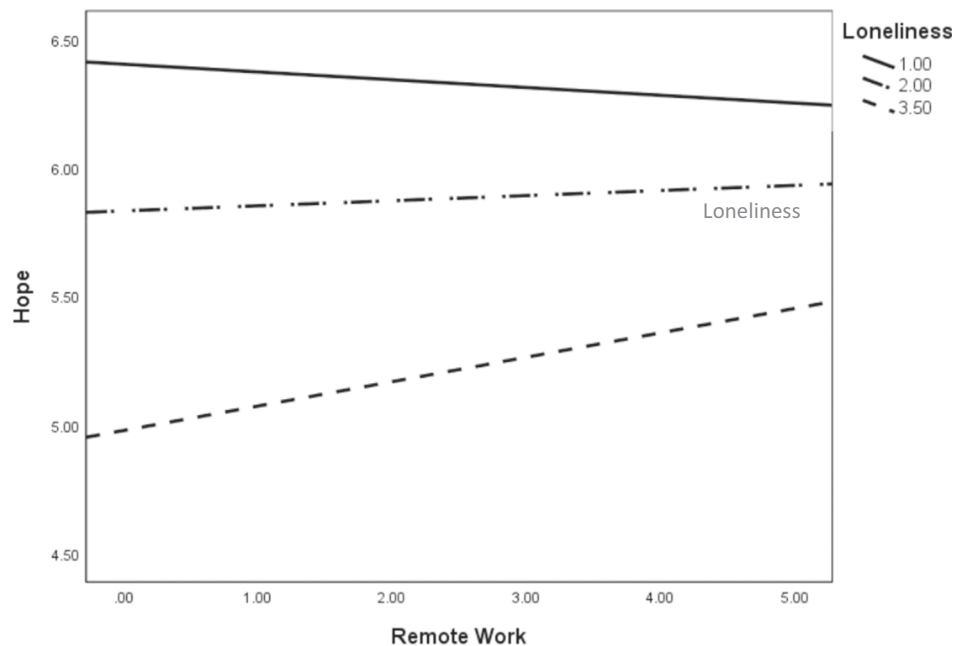


Fig. 3. The interaction between remote work and loneliness predicting hope.

dilemma of allowing remote work. This study indicates that in terms of job engagement, there is no inherent harm in implementing remote work policies.

The current study focus on employees who may be emotionally detached from the organization as a result of shifting to remote or hybrid work – the lonely employees. Research already demonstrates the effectiveness of interventions to reduce loneliness across the lifespan in different cultures (Eccles & Qualter, 2021; Hickin et al., 2021). A meta-analysis of loneliness reduction interventions, found that cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT) and mindfulness were effective (Hickin et al., 2021). Different workplaces offer programs to empower employee well-being, and it has been suggested that organizations that work remotely should offer well-being promotion programs focused on reducing loneliness. The implications of our findings call for enhancing hope for lonely employees since hope may activate the job engagement even in remote work among these people.

Effective interventions to cultivate hope (Bernardo & Sit, 2020) may be proposed. For example, a single focused workshop was found

effective in inducing hope (Feldman & Dreher, 2012), as well as multiple sessions (Cheavens et al., 2006). Embedding hope as one of the core values in the organizational culture was identified as a possible means of raising hope levels throughout the organization (Sheehan & Rall, 2011). In that sense, our findings have the important practical implication of raising levels of job engagement among lonely remote employees by inducing hope.

4.1. Limitations and future directions

Our study is not without limitations, one of which is the fact that it was correlational and used a single sample which may increase the risk of common method variance CMV. While several scholars have argued that common method variance does not invalidate most research findings (e.g., Spector, 2006), we used procedural design procedures (confidentiality and anonymity, and separate questionnaire sections and instructions) to minimize this risk. All the scales we used were established and valid, and we used attention check questions to test

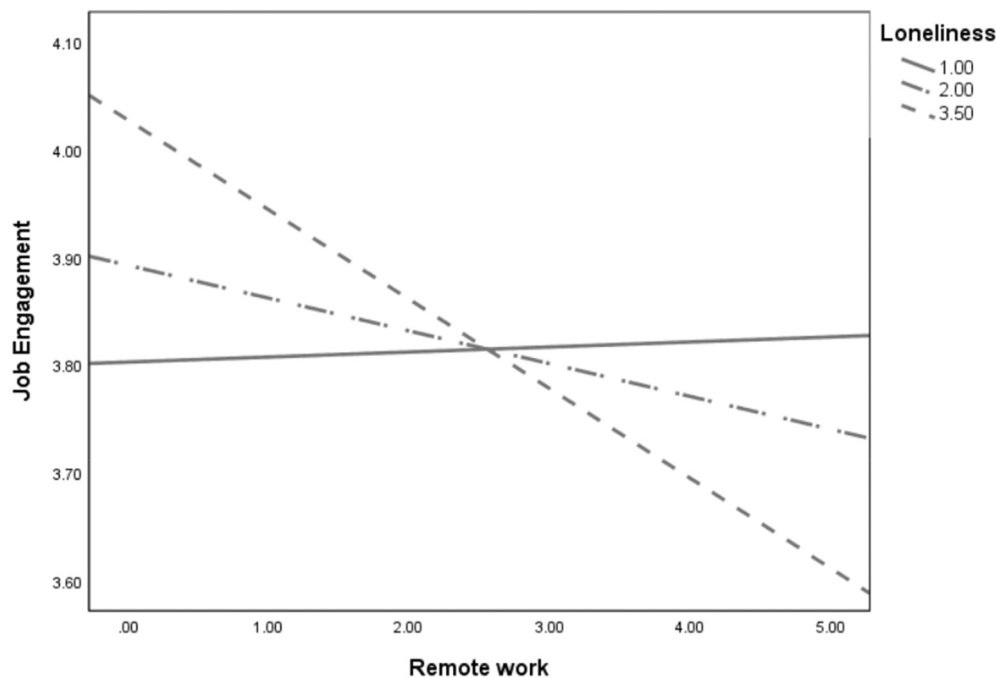


Fig. 4. The interaction between remote work and loneliness predicting job-engagement.

participants' focus (Podsakoff et al., 2003).

Another limitation has to do with the lack of equal representation of the full range of the remote work, with a high percentage of participants working five days remotely. An experimental design should be applied in the future to examine how specific differences in the amount of time working remotely may differentially impact job engagement.

In addition to duration, other driving and restraining forces must be added to this equation. Future studies should examine burnout and how it relates to remote work and job engagement and different levels of loneliness and hope (De Gieter et al., 2022).

Last, our findings are an expression of individual differences in response to situational consequences—remote work. A new stream of research is addressing the motivation of personal growth through the experience of discomfort (Woolley & Fishbach, 2022). Our findings regarding hope's mediation of the relationship between remote work and job engagement for people with high loneliness levels, while unexpected, suggest a positive path through which efforts can be directed inward through the mechanism of hope. Future studies should focus on the role of social stimuli for those who work remotely and specifically on the implications of remote work environments for people who lack external stimuli, such as lonely individuals.

5. Conclusions

The Great Resignation is here (Parker & Mehashe-Horowitz, 2022). We should therefore address flexibility at work as an enabling factor, focus on resilience factors, and identify additional ways to connect employees emotionally to the organization without requiring their physical presence. Above all, the current study suggests that it cannot be assumed that full-time physical presence in the organization is required to maintain employee engagement.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Liad Bareket-Bojmel: Conceptualization, Methodology, Investigation, Resources, Formal analysis, Visualization, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing, Project administration. **Lily Chernyak-Hai:** Conceptualization, Investigation, Resources, Writing – review & editing,

Project administration. **Malka Margalit:** Conceptualization, Methodology, Writing – review & editing, Project administration.

Data availability

Data will be made available on request.

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